Macbeth:
Contextual Background

high key ENGLISH

What does AQA say about context?

Context is the **understanding of the relationship between the ideas in the text and the contexts of the text**.

Here are some examples of context:

- ★ **When the text was written**: author, date, historical events
- ★ **When the text is set**: location, social structures, cultural contexts, time periods
- ★ **Literary traditions**: genre, literary traditions, different audiences

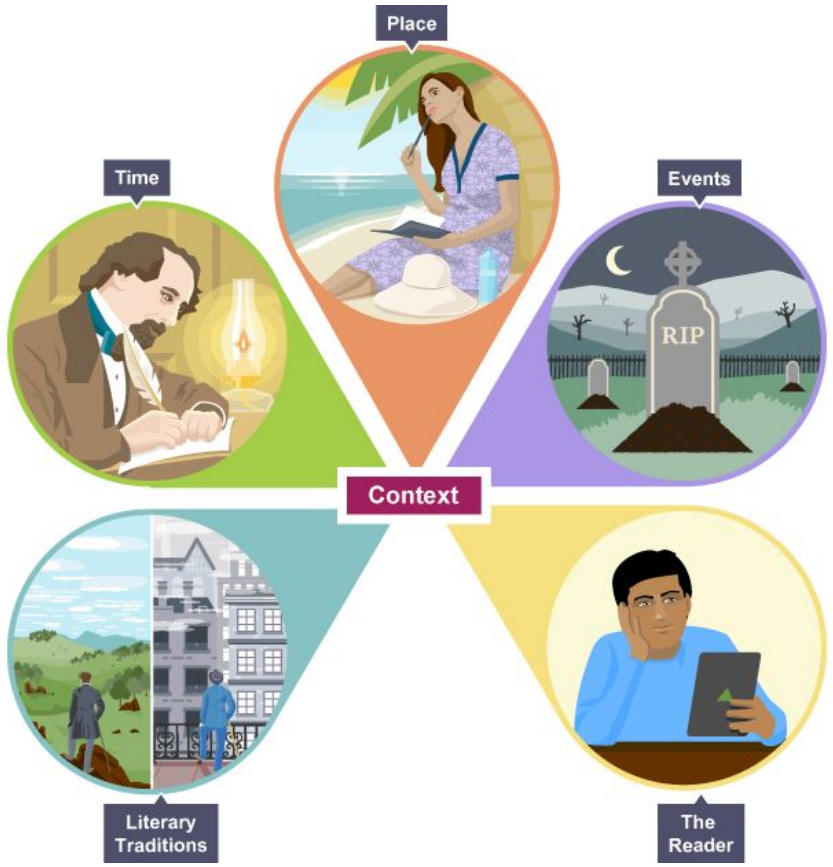


Image credit: BBC Bitesize

Why should I care about context?

Context is one of your **assessment objectives (AOs)** for *Macbeth*, in Paper 1.

6/30 (20%) marks are awarded for **AO3** context.

You should aim for **one context point per paragraph** of your essay.

Assessment objectives (AOs)

AO1	Read, understand and respond to texts. Students should be able to: • maintain a critical style and develop an informed personal response • use textual references, including quotations, to support and illustrate interpretations.
AO2	Analyse the language, form and structure used by a writer to create meanings and effects, using relevant subject terminology where appropriate.
AO3	Show understanding of the relationships between texts and the contexts in which they were written.
AO4	Use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures for clarity, purpose and effect, with accurate spelling and punctuation.

high key ENGLISH

Brainstorming time!

Jot down any context about *Macbeth* you already know in the space below.

★ 'Macbeth' was a play written by William Shakespeare and first performed c.1606...

high key ENGLISH

William Shakespeare (1564-1616)

- ★ Shakespeare is England's most famous playwright. He mainly wrote 3 kinds of plays: **comedies, tragedies and histories**.
- ★ Shakespeare's plays **entertained the masses** - people of all classes and backgrounds watched them, not just the rich. Remember that first and foremost, these plays were written to **enjoy**!
- ★ *Macbeth* was first performed c.**1606**, a few years after King James I ascended to the throne.

Play Match-Up

Can you identify whether each play is a **comedy**, **tragedy** or **history**?

Comedy

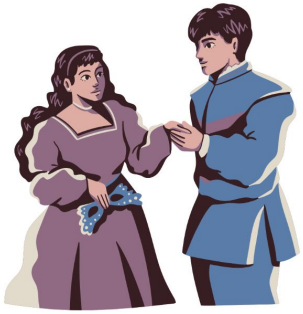
A Midsummer Night's Dream

Tragedy

Macbeth

Tragedy

Romeo and Juliet



History

Henry V

high key ENGLISH

King James I (1566-1625)

- ★ King James I was the **King of England** from 1603-1625. However, he had been **King of Scotland** since 1567 - at the age of 1!
- ★ Shakespeare had been popular with Queen Elizabeth I (the previous monarch). James I was still a recent king when *Macbeth* was performed, so Shakespeare wanted to **flatter** him.
- ★ James I was also **Shakespeare's patron**, so he would have watched his plays, and taken a great interest in them.

What do you think the term 'Jacobean era' means?

high key ENGLISH

King James I (1566-1625)

- ★ King James I wanted to **unify the three nations** of England, Scotland and Ireland into 'Great Britain'.
- ★ In a similar way, Malcolm unites the lords and thanes of England and Scotland at the end of the play.
- ★ On the other hand, Macbeth is depicted as a tyrant, **creating division** among his people.

'Thou shalt **get kings**, though thou be none' (the witches, Act I, Scene 3)

King James I believed he was descended from a medieval thane called Banquo.

(a) Why might this be relevant to the quote on the right?

(b) What kind of character is Banquo in the play and what does this have to do with James I's beliefs?

high key ENGLISH

The Gunpowder Plot (1605)

- ★ Throughout English history, there has always been tension between **Catholicism and Protestantism**.
- ★ Because James I was Protestant, Jacobean England was also Protestant. However, not everyone was happy about this.
- ★ The gunpowder plot was a **Catholic conspiracy**, led by Guy Fawkes, to kill James I on **November 5th, 1605** and put a Catholic monarch on the throne.
- ★ The plotters were caught, tortured and executed.
- ★ Those who did not follow the dominant religious domination were killed for their beliefs.
- ★ In the UK we still celebrate Bonfire Night, or 'Guy Fawkes Night', every year.

high key ENGLISH

Acts of Treason

The gunpowder plot was an act of **treason**. In *Macbeth*, acts of treason have terrible consequences. Wary that James I was watching his plays, Shakespeare warned that anyone who betrayed the king would suffer eternal consequences. Fill out the table below explaining what happens when treason is committed.

Act of treason	**Who commits it**	**Consequence**
Regicide (murder of the king)	Macbeth (with Lady Macbeth)	Macbeth does take the throne, but is plagued by guilt, paranoia, tyranny, and is killed.
Plot to murder Banquo		
Ordering the murder of Macduff's family		

The Divine Right of Kings

*This king is depicted as a giant figure towering over the land, suggesting that he has **supreme and uncontested authority** over his domain.*

*He is holding a sword and a 'crosier'; the sword **symbolises** military power, the crosier, religious authority. This **religious imagery** suggests that the king is close to God.*

The king's body is made up of tiny figures, suggesting the people both belong to and depend on the ruler. This implies that without a rightful king, society would simply collapse.

*This image depicts **order and unity** under a single ruler, much like Scotland when Duncan is still king. It also explains the chaos when Macbeth takes the throne.*

★ This illustration exemplifies a key bit of context called the '**Divine Right of Kings**'.

Divine Right of Kings

- ★ The illustration you've just seen is the **frontispiece** from Thomas Hobbes' *Leviathan* (1651). (A frontispiece is a full-page illustration facing the title page of a book.)
- ★ In the book, Hobbes - a political theorist - argues for an **absolute sovereign** with undivided power; he claims this was the only way to ensure peace.
- ★ King James believed in the Divine Right of Kings - that he was **ordained by God** to rule over his country. By betraying his king, Macbeth has effectively betrayed God.
- ★ This is not only treason - it is **sacrilegious** (going against a sacred belief).

high key ENGLISH

The Great Chain of Being

- ★ This is a philosophy where everything has a fixed place in the hierarchy of the universe—from rocks, to animals, to people.
- ★ The king is the closest being to God on Earth. It was therefore the role of the king to enact the will of God.
- ★ When Macbeth kills Duncan, this act of regicide is not only a sin against the state but also **against the very order of the universe**.

high key ENGLISH

The Great Chain of Being

How do these three quotes from *Macbeth* below highlight the philosophies of the Divine Right of Kings and the Great Chain of Being?

'A falcon towering in her pride of place / Was by a **mousing owl** hawked at and killed' - Old Man, Act II, Scene 4

Most **sacrilegious murder** hath broke ope / The Lord's **anointed temple**' - Macduff, Act II, Scene 3

"Tis said [Duncan's horses] **eat each other**' - Old Man, Act II, Scene 4

_____

_____

_____

_____

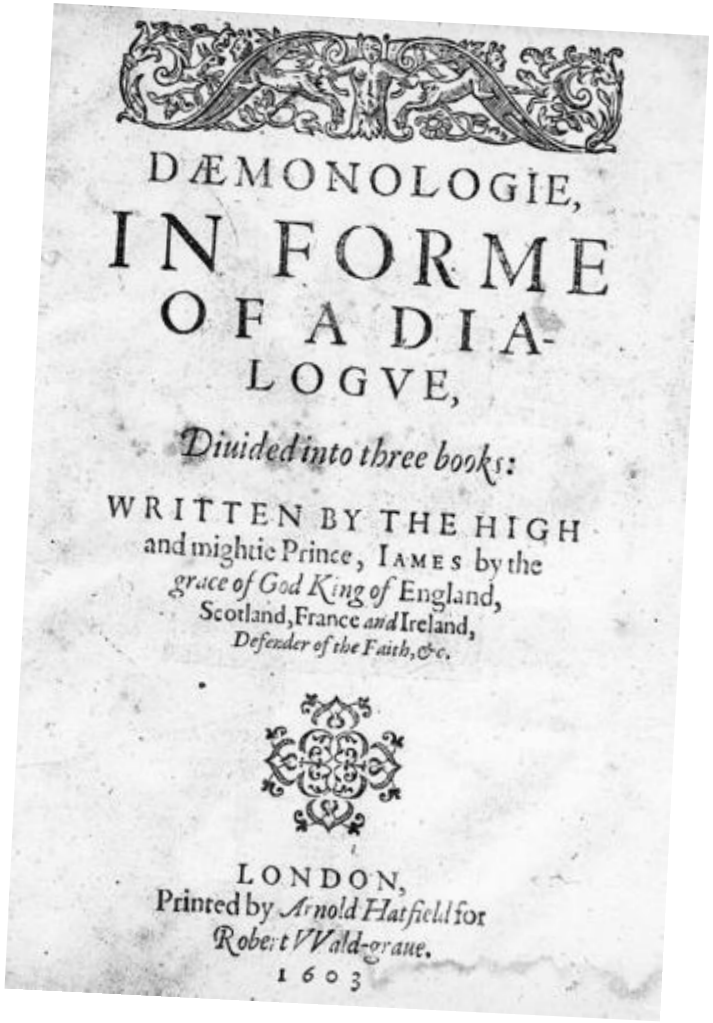
_____

_____

high key ENGLISH

Witchcraft and Women

- ★ King James I wrote a book called ***Daemonologie***, which means 'the science of demons'. It was published in 1603, when he became king.
- ★ James I believed that witchcraft was an act of Satan. It was a way to inspire people to carry out witch-hunts, which was an accepted practice then.
- ★ The publication of *Daemonologie* led to **increased persecution** of supposed 'witches'.
- ★ He enacted a new law making witchcraft **punishable by death**.


DÆMONOLOGIE,
IN FORME
OF A DIA-
LOGVE,
Diuided into three books:
WRITTEN BY THE HIGH
and mightie Prince, IAMES by the
grace of God King of England,
Scotland, France and Ireland,
Defender of the Faith, &c.
LONDON,
Printed by Arnold Hatfield for
Robert Wald-graue.
1603

high key ENGLISH

Witchcraft and women

- ★ In *Daemonologie*, James I wrote that only women could be witches as they were the '**weaker sex**', easily entrapped by the 'snares' of the devil.
- ★ He looked to the story of **Adam and Eve**, given Eve was tricked by the Devil, showing women to be more easily persuaded to evil.
- ★ In the Jacobean era, women were **subservient** to men; they had very little power, with restricted opportunities for education, employment and independence.

How might the publication of this book affect the way a contemporary audience would have perceived (a) the three witches and (b) women?

Witchcraft and Women

How does the character of Lady Macbeth compare to stereotypical attitudes toward women?

How Lady Macbeth **conforms** to stereotypical attitudes toward women

- ★ She conforms to the stereotype of the 'weaker sex' who succumbs easily to evil and temptation.
- ★ It is ultimately Macbeth who commits the murder, as Duncan resembles her father too much.
- ★ She eventually becomes fragile and mentally unstable as she is overwhelmed by guilt.

(Hint: think back to what King James I wrote in Daemonologie.*)*

How Lady Macbeth **defies** stereotypical attitudes towards women

- ★ She rejects her femininity by calling upon the spirits to 'unsex me here'.
- ★ She rejects her maternal instincts, an expected female trait, by claiming she would kill her own child.
- ★ She dominates her husband by controlling the decision making and orchestrating their plans.

high key ENGLISH

Setting: 11th century Scotland

- ★ While Macbeth is written in England 1606, the play is set in **11th century Scotland** (more specifically, between 1040 and 1057).
- ★ At the time, Scotland was a **separate country** to England - there was no 'United Kingdom'.
- ★ Scotland was often involved in bloody wars with England.

How do you think the the setting of Scotland informs the atmosphere of the play?

h key
NGLISH

Setting: 11th century Scotland

Shakespeare chose Scotland for its dark, wet, eerie climate and atmosphere. Which of these key scenes do you think the **setting** plays a critical role?

- Lady Macbeth and Macbeth arguing about the murder (Act 1, Scene 7)
- Macbeth meeting the witches on the 'blasted heath' (Act 1, Scene 1 & 3)
- The final battle at Dunsinane Castle (Act 5)
- Lady Macbeth sleepwalking (Act 5)

Pick one and explain why you think the setting is vital to that point in the play.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

high key ENGLISH

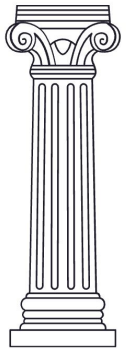
Greek tragedy

Like ancient Greek tragedies, *Macbeth* follows a traditional **five-act structure**. It also shares these two features with Greek tragedy:

- ★ **Hamartia**: literally means 'fatal flaw', the character flaw that leads to the protagonist's reversal of fortune, from prosperity to tragedy.
- ★ **Catharsis**: means 'cleansing' or 'purging' of emotions, particularly pity and fear, which the audience experiences at the end of the tragedy.

high key ENGLISH

Greek tragedy

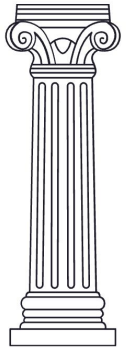


1. What do you think is Macbeth's **hamartia** and why?

_____

_____

_____



2. Name one **cathartic** scene in *Macbeth* and explain why you think it would have elicited such a strong reaction from the audience.

_____

_____

_____

high key ENGLISH

Adam and Eve

Chapter 3 of Genesis (Old Testament) famously recounts the story of Adam and Eve and their betrayal of God, as they are tempted by Satan in serpent form to eat an apple from the tree of life.

What relevance does this story have to *Macbeth*?

'The Garden of Eden and the Fall of Man', by Peter Paul Rubens and Jan Brueghel the Elder

high key ENGLISH

The Holinshed 'Chronicles'

- ★ Holinshed's *Chronicles* (1577) was one of the source texts for *Macbeth*. It describes the histories of England, Scotland and Ireland, and accounts in particular the story of King Duncan and Macbeth.
- ★ In the original work, Banquo is an **accomplice** of Macbeth in the murder of King Duncan.
- ★ The *Chronicles* are largely accepted as narrative.

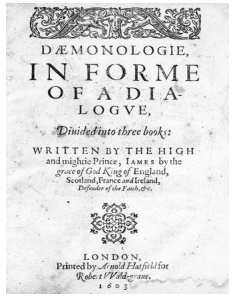
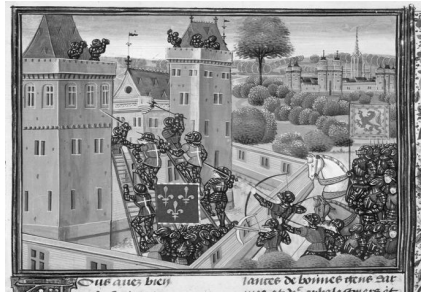
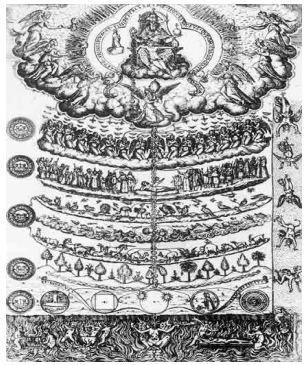
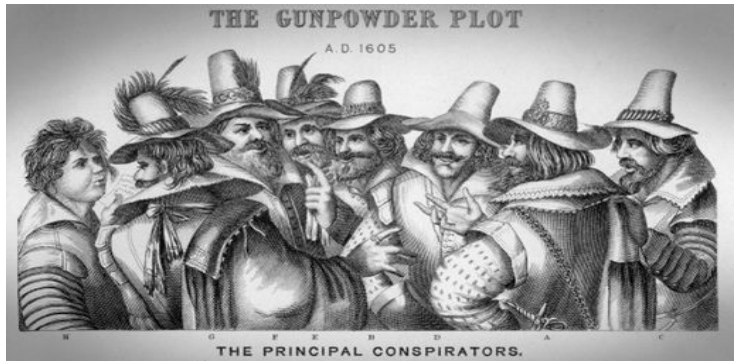
1577.

THE
Firste volume of the
Chronicles of England, Scotlande, and Irelande.
CONTEYNING

AT LONDON
Imprinted for Lucas Harrison.

God saue the Queene.

Discuss: Why would Shakespeare decide to recast Banquo's role in the story?

high key ENGLISH

Recap activity